If India and China are to mend their relations, if not end the border quarrel and deal with other differences, their deeply rooted negative perceptions of each other will have to change. Unfortunately, the changes have been in the wrong direction. Indeed, the Ladakh crisis, the worst since 1962, could be a turning point for the worse. *India Today* magazine's 'Mood of the Nation' survey of public opinion in August 2020 is revealing. Nearly 60 per cent surveyed wanted India to go to war over Ladakh, and 70 per cent thought that it could win a war. Nearly half held China responsible for the crisis. Indians overwhelmingly did not trust Xi Jinping and China: 84 per cent said that Xi had betrayed Modi. Ninety per cent favoured boycotting Chinese products, and 91 per cent supported the measures against Chinese apps and contracts in India. Sixty-seven per cent were even prepared to pay more for goods not made in China.[1]

As it turns out, the Chinese public was polled about India, also in August 2020. *Global Times* and the China Institutes of Contemporary International Relations (CICIR) reported that 70 per cent of those surveyed thought that India was being too hostile in the wake of Ladakh. Ninety per cent supported strong retaliatory action against India if it were to provoke China. On the other hand, 57 per cent felt that India was no threat to China militarily, and 50 per cent noted that India was heavily dependent on Chinese products. More than half thought that in terms of comprehensive national power, India would never surpass China. Interestingly, over 70 per cent said they 'had a clear understanding' of or were very familiar with India. And in a list of 'most favourable neighbours' of China (that is, most liked), India surprisingly ranked fourth, ahead of South Korea.[2] Allowing for the possible unreliability of the Indian and Chinese surveys, given that they were conducted at a time of crisis between India and China, they mostly present a discouraging picture of mutual perceptions.

The original quarrel over perimeters has been made worse by India's reorganization of Jammu and Kashmir in August 2019 and China's rejection of it. After India's decision to abrogate Article 370 of the Constitution and remove Jammu and Kashmir's special status, Home Minister Amit Shah was quoted as having said, 'Kashmir is an integral part of India, there is no